

Nokia N96

The Return Of The King?

Nokia's N95 8 GB was, perhaps, one of the most balanced Symbian-based smartphones we've ever had the pleasure of reviewing. Most people look at such high-end phones as a sum of their feature set. For us, a cellphone is a more personal device, and the operation, ergonomics, intuitiveness of menus and ease of use are equally important as the features — especially when one is shelling out over Rs 30,000.

The N82 was thought to be a replacement for the N95, but without the slick two way slider, and a smaller screen, it was never an N95 killer. Now Nokia faced a dilemma — how to improve upon near perfection? Simple — improve the few noticeable flaws. And thus was born the N96.

Livered in a slick satin black facia with metallic silver all round the sides. The rear is satin black, with fine grey lines between — very similar to the finishes on the Nokia N82 and N78. Some may like such finishes — we personally don't, and the N95 8 GB looked much more a serious phone than a rich boy's play-toy.

The screen remains the same (2.8 inches) although it's now become glossy, which gives the appearance of better contrast, but in reality this isn't so. The speaker grilles are now much better looking. The revamping of the menu buttons isn't successful however, and the four-way joypad is now much harder to use. The menu button isn't bevelled any more and its flush fit and closeness to the call accept button may lead to a few false key presses — very annoying. The volume and camera buttons on the side are now a lot

harder to use, and feel tackier than the N95s keys. The number pad now has flat keys and their close spacing means using them is a pain — the N95 8 GB had bevelled keys — Nokia should have stuck with that.

The N96 is much slimmer than its predecessor. Oh joy right? Well, the downside is the battery, which has gone from a hefty 1200 mAh, to 950 mAh — something that's sure to displease most people especially considering it's such a feature-rich, high-end device.

Nokia also dropped the 332 MHz ARM 11 for a slower

265 MHz ARM 9 CPU and this is evident during general use — the phone is more sluggish. The inbuilt storage has seen a dramatic increase to 16 GB. Nokia finally did something right and added MicroSD expansion as well, which the N95 8 GB missed. An 8 GB card is bundled as well meaning you save a chunk of cash on the same. A slightly newer version of Symbian S 60 (V 9.3 in lieu of V 9.2) is used. The same 5 MP camera is also present, now with a slightly more powerful dual-LED flash — why no Xenon flash?

Connectivity remains excellent, ditto applications — the N96 is a truly connected, converged device. Signal quality is as good as

the N95 8 GB, which was pretty excellent. Music quality is as good, but the N95 8 GB remains a little louder in terms of maximum volumes — no complaints though. Owing to the slower CPU, and maybe slower flash memory, the video folder takes a fair bit of time to refresh the previews of videos.

So the verdict — is the N96 worth it or not? Sure — it's arguably funkier looking, slightly sleeker, and has a high quality finish, in addition to having more storage. But to many these are superficial changes. Under the hood, it's not any better than the N95 8 GB, and is inferior in terms of processing speed and battery life. The button layout is also not as comfortable, a fact which becomes an annoyance — especially to anyone who has spent time with its predecessor.

Nokia has created a great phone — but they haven't exceeded the standards they set in 2007 with the N95 8 GB — a fact which irritates us as reviewers. As history proves succession isn't a guarantee of superiority. Check out both phones before you buy this — either way you cannot go wrong in terms of getting a superb phone.

Specifications

ARM 9 265 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 16 GB storage, MicroSD expansion, 5 MP camera

Contact: Nokia India Pvt. Ltd.
E-mail: communications.india@nokia.com
Phone: 0124-4199000
Web site: www.nokia.com
Price: Rs 34,999

RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



Intex IT-10500W

Pretty Decent!

Intex's IT-10500W are a pair of floorstanders that look like some of the more well known brands seen in most electronics showrooms. These are floor standers, so there's no separate woofer unit.

The speakers perform fine through all of the tests. There is a little distortion when the volume is turned up beyond the 80 per cent mark. The hard drum beats come out really well, and the boomy bass is present as well. The crisp highs are not as prominent as in some of the high-end speakers. The tone in general isn't very neutral either. The sound is more inclined towards the higher mid-range frequencies.

These speakers are rated at 42 W RMS each, and

should be enough for a decent sized living room. They're loud enough, and must be used while sitting at least a few feet away. The best use we can think of for them is to use them with a television set or as just speakers for a music system.

A big wireless microphone is bundled, and the speakers have a volume and an echo control for the microphone. Quality is average, but it is a nice feature to have for karaoke.

At Rs 5,450, it is good value for money. They might not have the best sound, but with the output power and the compactness that these speakers have, they could supplement the average TV's inbuilt speakers.

LG KC550

Slide-n-shoot

The glossy black front with shiny metal accents looks good on the LG KC550 while the matte rubber finish at the back of it helps handling and adds on to the good looks. The glossy front is, however, a smudge magnet. The 2.4-inch colour display, with a QVGA resolution of 240 x 320 pixels, is bright, and quite vibrant.

The build quality of the KC550 is good, thanks to its partial metallic body.

The keys are brightly lit and well spaced out for comfortable operation. The overall built quality of the keys is good.

This phone is still a triband phone, and that's just sad. However, the signal reception of this phone is

good, and you will not get disconnected every now and then in areas of lower signal strength.

The KC 550 sports a 5 Megapixel autofocus camera with a power LED flash and a self portrait mirror. It's capable of capturing images with a maximum resolution of 2592 x 1944 pixels. The camera uses Schneider-Kreuznach certified optics, and is protected by a sleek shutter with a stylish brown metallic accent.

On the video recording front, this camera is a star with the ability to record video at a resolution of 720 x 480 pixels at 30FPS. The phone has an inbuilt accelerometer, and can automatically change screen orientation based on the way you hold it.

The KC 550 has a 900 mAh battery which can take



Specifications:

Frequency response: 50 Hz to 20 kHz, Bundled microphone
Dimensions: 15 x 30 x 66 cm.

Contact: Intex Technologies (India) Ltd

Phone: 011-41610224

E-mail: info@intextechnologies.com

Web site:

www.intextechnologies.com

Price: Rs 5,450

RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

up to 3 days of moderate usage with just a single charge.

Finally, to sum it up, the KC 550 with its exceptional 5 MP camera and a low price turns out to be a good competitor. Before you go out and buy one, you should remember that it does not support GPS and isn't 3G ready. If these don't matter to you, the KC550, priced at Rs 15,990, is a good deal.

Specifications:

2.4-inch colour display, 5 MP autofocus camera, 1 GB memory card bundled, loudspeaker, FM, MP3 Player.

Contact: LG Electronics India Pvt. Ltd.

Phone: 0120-2560900

E-mail: viveksingh@lgindia.com

Web site: www.lgindia.com

Price: Rs 15,990



RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★